Facing a Democratic Congress, Trump Should Consider Resigning

L. Ali Khan | Washburn University School of Law | US

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Republicans may have their own reason to persuade Trump to step aside: a reset under Vance could improve their odds of winning back seats and holding the White House in 2028.

In more than two centuries of US history, only one president, **Richard Nixon**, has resigned. None has been removed from office through impeachment. Calls for President Donald Trump to resign following his party's midterm losses thus have little historical precedent. Following the November 2026 midterm elections, Republicans will **lose control** of both chambers of Congress. But many presidents, including Bill Clinton in 1994, Barack Obama in 2010 and Joe Biden in 2022, saw their parties lose control of one or both chambers midway through their presidencies and this didn't stop them from discharging the duties of office.

Losing control of the House and Senate in a midterm election is not a sufficient reason to resign from the presidency, and that is not the argument here. The argument is that Trump will become highly ineffective in domestic and foreign policy as a Democratic Congress, with the massive mandate it received in the midterms, doggedly opposes him.

This commentary recognizes that President Trump will not violate any tradition if he completes his four years. Yet if he decides to resign, his resignation will bring concrete benefits to democracy at home, to international peace and security, and to the **global economy**, which is under **extreme hardship** after the on-and-off closure of the Hormuz Strait following the war with Iran. President Trump may even benefit personally from resigning, as he would avoid the pressure of staying in office when opponents are freshly energized and ready to resist his presidency by any means necessary.

If President Trump resigns, Vice President JD Vance will become President under Section 1 of the 25th **Amendment**: "In case of the removal of the President from office or of his death or resignation, the Vice President shall become President." The successor President, without any obligation to prior policies, will be better positioned to govern, though there is no inherent guarantee that the new President will abandon prior policies or otherwise succeed with a Democratic Congress.

Despite the resignation, the presidency remains with the Republican Party, and the Democrats gain no additional institutional benefit from the change. If the successor president sheds the policy baggage the previous president carried, inter-party dynamics might shift, but the inter-party power equation does not. The resignation would reset democratic dynamics and create new opportunities for cooperation between the new President and Congress.

Congressional Investigations

Congressional investigations and impeachments of officials, integral to the Constitution, safeguard executive accountability, even though the Supreme Court has conferred extensive immunity on current and former Presidents. However, this immunity does not extend to impeachment and removal. Cabinet members, the President's family and friends, and even military officials enjoy no such immunity from the criminal justice system. A presidential resignation does not preempt congressional investigations, though it preempts the threat of removal from office, even if impeachment remains a **constitutional possibility**.

Perhaps the people are the biggest beneficiaries of Trump's resignation, as Congress devotes its energy to solving their problems rather than investigating and impeaching the President. The resignation will save Congressional resources that would likely be spent **investigating** the President, his cabinet officials, family members, and friends who conducted peace negotiations in the Iran and Ukraine wars. In his first term, 2017-2021, a Democratic House **impeached** President Trump twice, consuming Congressional time. Impeachment is a costly procedure, with taxpayers bearing the expense; it also diverts Congressional resources from productive legislative work the nation needs.

It seems highly likely that, empowered by midterm victories across the board, including in state legislatures and governorships, even in some red states like **Kansas**, an emboldened Democratic Party will be eager to impeach President Trump and his officials as soon as the next Congressional session begins in January 2027. The idea that the new Congress should focus on productive work, not on investigations and impeachments, is unlikely to materialize because, like voters, political opponents are determined to punish the President for his policies, including the Iran war, **ICE cruelty**, tariffs, clash with Canada, and personal indignities inflicted on **members of Congress**.

There is no guarantee the Democrats will decide not to investigate him and his associates if the President resigns. President Trump will have absolute immunity from criminal prosecution for core constitutional acts and a presumptive immunity for **official acts**. Still, prosecuting his family and associates remains an option, even if it leads to no conviction. It cannot be said with certainty what pardons the successor president would offer Trump's family and associates, though the prospect of pardons might incentivize Trump to resign. The animosity would increase if Trump stayed in power.

Dynamics of a Divided Government

The 2026 midterm elections will produce a divided government. When each party controls one House, Congress is divided. When one party controls one or both Houses, and the other party controls the Presidency, we have a divided government. When the same party controls both Houses and the Presidency, we have a **single-party government**. President Trump enjoyed **single-party rule for the past two years**, as Republicans controlled both Congress and the Presidency.

A party might covet control of both Congress and the Presidency; however, that is certainly not good for the nation, which benefits from a more competitive democracy. US democracy works best when the two parties are equally powerful, negotiating differing agendas through debate, compromise, and occasional deadlock that is part of the system.

When the same party controls the Presidency, Congress, the power of the purse, and key committees that set agendas, the consequences are far less desirable because the opposition party lacks effective power to resist the Executive, as has been the case with President Trump. Some negative outcomes in the midterm elections stemmed from voters pushing back against the bad policies of a **Trump-led single-party government** that pursued vengeance at home and reckless policies abroad.

In 2018, President Trump lost the House in his first term, not the Senate. In 2027, he will have lost both the House and the Senate. With Democratic control of Congress, the discord shifts from inter-party divergence in a divided Congress to a direct conflict between the Democratic Congress and the Republican presidency, a situation Trump has not faced before. Dealing with a single opposing House is much easier than dealing with both opposing Houses of Congress.

President Trump's **threat to veto** Democratic legislation will paralyze matters. The presidential veto is a highly effective tool when the President disagrees with the majority's decisions and forces a supermajority to support legislation. The same tool becomes dysfunctional when it targets legislation simply because it comes from a dominant party in Congress. A divided government needs bipartisan solutions, not the veto.

No presidential resignation will change the institutional divide between a Democratic Congress and a Republican presidency starting in January 2027. Whether Trump or Vance controls the White House, it would still be an inter-branch conflict. However, the degree and severity of conflict might change. If Vance changes some policies, a Democratic Congress might be more willing to cooperate; the ill will toward Trump might subside when dealing with Vance, who, unlike Trump, has **served as a senator** in Congress.

Ironically, the Republican Party might support Trump's resignation. Such a resignation would bolster the party as the successor President resets the party's agenda and repairs the damage shown by the midterms. If Trump does not resign, the inter-party balance may tilt further in Democrats' favor, making it much easier for them to elect a Democratic president in 2028. Thus, it may be in the Republican Party's interest to persuade Trump to leave office to boost its chances of winning back some lost seats in Congress in the next election.

Ending the Iran War

President Trump himself **admits** that the Iran war was a major reason for his party's defeat in the midterm elections. However, bringing the Iran war to a close would require extensive effort and a change in the Iranian perception that has been severely distorted since the war began in February 2026. Iran does not trust President Trump, as he initiated the war, **breaching good**

faith while the parties were negotiating. If President Trump continues, negotiations to end the war and revitalize the global economy will remain mired in mistrust.

The Iran war, no matter how justified from a US perspective, has seriously jolted the global economy, with commodity and **shipping insurance** prices skyrocketing and supply chains disrupted. The global economy is so interlocked that removing any major country, such as Iran, from the transactional economy leads to major disruptions. The attack on the Gulf states further aggravated the regional economy. The closure of the Strait of Hormuz hurt **many nations** far more than it hurt Iran. US prices for various household goods increased, infuriating **American consumers**.

Relatively, the successor President will be better positioned to negotiate an end to the Iran War. Vance led the US side of the negotiations that produced the **Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding** in June 2026 to end the war, which later became defunct as the parties disagreed and new conflicts arose; hostilities resumed, leading to a deadlock. Vance can reliably build on prior negotiations, as he publicly admits the Iran war has been a **political liability** in midterms.

It will be easier for the successor President to secure the concessions Iran needs to reopen its resource supplies to the world, benefiting American consumers as well. There is no guarantee Iran will be more hospitable to Vance than to Trump, but the odds favor Vance over Trump, as Vance has engaged in fruitful diplomacy with Iran through mediators. Unfortunately, President Trump enjoys no comparable trust with either regional mediators or Tehran.

Conclusion

President Trump has no obligation, only the option, to resign from office in favor of the Vice President. This change will not alter the inter-party power dynamics in 2027, as the Democrats will continue to control the House and the Senate, and the presidency will remain with the Republican Party. However, the switch will allow the new President to change course on domestic and international policies that rattled the electorate in the midterms. People want an end to the war with Iran, and they are unhappy with the elevated cost of living. The country will not benefit if the President remains in power, as Democrats will continue to exploit his weaknesses and may devote extensive resources to investigations and impeachment; they might let up on a successor President.

The Republican Party will be much better positioned to go to the 2028 polls under a successor Republican President than under a President who precipitated its catastrophic defeat in the 2026 midterms. It is therefore within the Republican Party's strategic interest to persuade the President to leave office, creating new opportunities to win back some of the seats lost in the midterms. Systemically, a robust party system serves the national interest, but it works only when the two parties remain competitive.

Stepping down from the supreme executive office might help President Trump, the Republican Party, and, most importantly, the American people seeking relief from high prices as a byproduct of the Iran war and an end to the uncertainty it has brought to the global economy.

Ali Khan is the founder of Legal Scholar Academy and an Emeritus Professor of Law at the Washburn University School of Law in Topeka, Kansas. He has written numerous scholarly articles and commentaries on international law. In addition, he has regularly contributed to JURIST since 2001. He welcomes comments at legal.scholar.academy@gmail.com

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